

The Möllers of Döschnitz

Prepared by Claude (Anthropic), with research direction and editorial oversight by Ryan E. Bock,
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Introduction

The Möller family (also rendered Moeller) enter the Bock genealogy through a single thread: Luise Pauline Möller, born in Döschnitz on 16 May 1844 to Johann Heinrich August Möller and his first wife, Friedericke née Säuberlich. This essay reconstructs who the Möllers were. The primary sources are the Möller documents in the Döschnitz-Meura church books on Archion — marriages, baptisms, and funeral entries spanning roughly 1830 to 1883 — supplemented by Emil Bock's handwritten family history of 6 January 1935 (Bock, Emil G., 1935, via Bock Mansholt, 1976–1978) and a 1931 letter from the Döschnitz village Pfarrer (pastor), Richard Kunze, to Emil (Kunze, 1931). Where the records run out, the essay says so.

From Weapons-Smith to Village Headman: The Möller Line

Pauline's paternal grandfather was **Johann Heinrich Möller**, a *Waffenschmied und Einwohner daselbst* — weapons-smith and resident of Döschnitz. He is known from a single record: the 1843 marriage entry for his son Johann Heinrich August, where he appears as *weiland* — already deceased (Archion: Döschnitz-Meura, Trauungen, 1843). His wife, Pauline's paternal grandmother, was **Anna Maria Weise**; her origins and dates remain unknown. The weapons-smith occupation is historically fitting for Döschnitz. The village's iron-working tradition stretched back to at least the 15th century — a hammer mill operated there until 1862, and the nearby hamlet bears the name Bockschmiede, pointing to old metalworking roots in the area. A *Waffenschmied* was a skilled specialist within that tradition, making and repairing bladed tools and weapons. In practice, the term in a village of this size often covered a broader range of bladed iron goods than the formal guild designation implies — knives, edge tools, agricultural implements — but it designated a recognized craft position and a man with standing.

Johann Heinrich and Anna Maria's son, **Johann Heinrich August Möller** — known as August — was born 28 August 1809 in Döschnitz, the second child and second son of their only marriage. He began his working life as a *Meister Schneider*, master tailor, a trade he pursued through the 1840s and 1850s as his children's baptismal records consistently show. By 1871, however, the Döschnitz-Meura marriage register describes him as *Ökonom und Ortsvorsteher* — farmer and village headman — and an earlier variant in Pauline's own marriage record uses the older term *Schultheiß*, a synonym that reflects the transitional administrative terminology of the period (Archion: Döschnitz-Meura, Trauungen 1822–1875, Bild 136).

The *Ortsvorsteher* was the principal administrative officer of the village, responsible for local governance, tax collection, and public order under Schwarzburg-Rudolstadt state authority. Crucially, the position was not elected in any modern democratic sense: the village commune's *Nachbarschaft* (the body of propertied male citizens) had a role in proposing candidates, but the Schwarzburg administrative apparatus — specifically the *Amt* at Königsee, which held jurisdiction over the upper Schwarza villages — confirmed

the appointment. To reach it, August Möller would have needed both property and the confidence of the state's local officials. In a village of some 400 to 600 people, it was the highest civic position a commoner could hold.

The trajectory from weapons-smith's son to master tailor to village headman across two generations is a coherent picture of upward mobility in a small Thuringian village. It also shapes the social framing of the Möller-Bock connection: Pauline was not a craftsman's daughter who married up into the family of the village physician, Dr. Johann Gottlob Bock. On the contrary, she was a village headman's daughter. The Möllers and Bocks were peers.

August had two brothers. The elder was **Johann Michael Möller**, whose family is discussed below. The younger was **Florenz Möller**, born 7 April 1818 in Döschnitz, the youngest of the three brothers. August died 20 June 1879 in Döschnitz, aged 69 (Bock, Emil G., 1935, via Bock Mansholt, 1976–1978).

The Säuberlich Family: Pauline's Maternal Roots

August's first wife was **Johanne Christiane Friedericke Säuberlich** — known by her *Rufname* Friedericke — born 25 April 1817 in Döschnitz. Her father was **Johann Georg Nicol Säuberlich**, merchant and full citizen of Döschnitz (*Handelsmann und mitnachbarlicher Einwohner*). Her mother was **Marie Barbara née Lippold**, who came from the village of Quelitz, roughly 15 kilometers northeast of Döschnitz — her origin established by the baptismal record of her younger daughter, which names both parents explicitly (Archion: Döschnitz-Meura, Taufen).

The 1843 marriage record describes Friedericke as the third child and eldest daughter of Johann Georg Nicol's only marriage (Archion: Döschnitz-Meura, Trauungen, 1843). Her younger sister, Christiane Luise Caroline Säuberlich, would later prove significant to Pauline's early childhood, as discussed below.

The Säuberlich name still appears among current gravestones at the Döschnitz churchyard, confirming the family's long persistence in the village (grabsteine.genealogy.net, Friedhof Döschnitz).

August's First Marriage

August and Friedericke Säuberlich married on 28 December 1843 in Döschnitz at 6 o'clock in the morning, *in Stille*, quietly and without public celebration. He was 34 and she was 26 (Archion: Döschnitz-Meura, Trauungen, 1843). Their union produced one surviving child: Pauline, who was born 16 May 1844 (Archion: Döschnitz-Meura, Taufen 1822–1847).

Less than five years later, the household was shattered. On 12 November 1848, Friedericke went into labor with twins and did not survive. The funeral register records her death and the death of one of the twins, Johann Friedrich Möller, in childbed; neither twin lived (Archion: Döschnitz-Meura, Beerdigungen 1822–1860, Bild 98). Friedericke was 31. August was 39, widowed, with a four-year-old daughter and a tailor's shop to maintain (Bock, Emil G., 1935, via Bock Mansholt, 1976–1978).

Childbed mortality was among the leading causes of death for women of reproductive age in mid-19th-century rural Germany (Wikipedia: Maternal death). A complicated twin labor in a Schwarzburg village, attended by a midwife without antiseptic technique, presented few options. Friederike's death was not exceptional by the grim standards of the period, but its consequences for her household were severe.

Christiane Luise Caroline Säuberlich, who went by Luise, was 18 years old at the time of her older sister Friederike's death. Luise may have played a vital role in the upbringing of her niece Pauline in the years after her mother's death. This is suggested by the fact that Pauline's oldest son, Emil, inquired about Luise's exact relationship to the family in a 1931 correspondence with Pfarrer Kunze (Kunze, 1931). Luise later married into the Höfer family and lived until 1 January 1903.

August's Second Marriage

Within a few years, August married for the second time. Emil's 1935 family history describes the bride only as "a Widow with one Daughter," without naming her. The Döschnitz funeral register confirms her identity as **Johanne Christiane Juliane Friederike Möller geb. Biehl**, born 18 December 1821. She died on 10 April 1883 of *Auszehrung*, the same wasting illness that had taken her husband four years earlier (Archion: Döschnitz-Meura, Beerdigungen 1861–1892).

August and Friederike Biehl had five documented children, listed here in birth order:

- **Eline Möller** (17 March 1850 – 24 May 1904): Married Emil Hermann Heissler. One of Emil Hermann's brothers had married Bertha Bock, Ottomar's older sister, connecting the Möller and Bock families at two distinct points before Ottomar and Pauline's own marriage.
- **Luise Agnes Friederike Möller** (15 August 1852 – ?): Almost certainly the "Louise Möller who died single" named in Emil's 1935 family history as having predeceased the 1898 estate distribution (Bock, Emil G., 1935, via Bock Mansholt, 1976–1978).
- **Ida Möller** (baptized 20 June 1854, death date not established): Married a Rosenbusch. Both the Heissler and Rosenbusch names appear among current gravestones at the Döschnitz churchyard (grabsteine.genealogy.net, Friedhof Döschnitz).
- **August Hermann Bruno Raimund Möller** (19 January 1856 – ?): Known in family tradition simply as Hermann (Bock, Emil G., 1935, via Bock Mansholt, 1976–1978).
- **Pauline Hulda Anna Möller** (baptized 8 May 1859 – 10 May 1935): Known as Anna. She married Paul Alfred Gerhardt on 25 November 1884, six months before Pauline Bock sailed for America, and had four children who lived well into the mid-20th century. She outlived Emil's 1935 family history by only weeks.

In addition, Emil's 1935 family history mentions an unnamed step-daughter whom Friederike Biehl brought into the household from her first marriage. That woman's identity has not been established in any surviving record (Bock, Emil G., 1935, via Bock Mansholt, 1976–1978).

The Möller Brothers and the 100-Year Estate

Johann Michael Möller, the eldest brother, married Friedericke Böttner. Their household was marked by severe child mortality: as many as three of their four documented children — Rosimunde Linna (1842–1843), Auguste Pauline Ida (1844–?), Florenz Emil Raimund (1852–1854), and Hermine Linna (1853–1854) — died in infancy or early childhood (Bock, Emil G., 1935, via Bock Mansholt, 1976–1978).

Florenz Möller, the youngest brother, married Pauline Kunze¹ at Döschnitz in 1860. Florenz was present in the village as late as 1877, when he was named as a godfather in Carl Bock's baptismal record (Archion: Döschnitz-Meura, Taufen 1868–1889, Bild 99). Emil notes in his family history that, in 1898, Florenz set aside an estate of approximately 3,000 dollars at compound interest to be divided among surviving Möller heirs in 1998. This was a bold and unusual gesture for a man of modest rural origins, and is perhaps explained in part by his lack of direct heirs (Bock, Emil G., 1935, via Bock Mansholt, 1976–1978).

The legal mechanism in late 19th-century Thuringia for a 100-year arrangement like this would have been a notarized trust deed (*Treuhandvertrag*) or testamentary deposit with the *Amtsgericht* — the successor court to the old *Justizamt* — at Königsee or at Rudolstadt (Wikipedia: Treuhand). Whether the trust survived the 1923 Weimar hyperinflation, which destroyed the real value of most fixed German savings instruments, and the 1948 Soviet-zone currency reform, is uncertain.

Pauline and Ottomar: The Döschnitz Years (1868–1885)

Village church records confirm that Ottomar and Pauline were married on 29 August 1871 (Archion: Döschnitz-Meura, Trauungen 1822–1875, Bild 136). This contradicts later accounts of an 1867 and 1868 wedding that appear in Emil's family history and Ottomar's Kansas obituary, among other sources. These latter accounts are almost certainly apocryphal, for reasons discussed below.

At the time of their marriage in the summer of 1871, Ottomar and Pauline had a three-year-old daughter, Clara (born 22 June 1868), and were expecting their second child, Emil, who would arrive just ten weeks after the ceremony on 3 November 1871 (Archion: Döschnitz-Meura, Taufen 1868–1889, Bild 7 and 35). Clara's birth had already presented significant challenges for the young family. In addition to being illegitimate in the eyes of the state, she had an intellectual disability.²

¹ It is unknown whether Pauline Kunze was a relative of Pfarrer Richard Kunze (10 November 1877 – 3 March 1948), the Döschnitz village pastor who wrote the informative 1931 letter to Emil Bock. Pfarrer Kunze and his wife Johanna are both buried in the Döschnitz churchyard (grabsteine.genealogy.net, Friedhof Döschnitz, Grab Kunze), and the Kunze surname shared between the pastor and Florenz's wife is, in a village of Döschnitz's size, unlikely to be coincidental.

² Clara traveled to Kansas with the family in 1885 and remained in her parents' household throughout their lives. After their deaths, her care passed through several guardianship arrangements (Smith County Pioneer, 2 Dec 1909; Lebanon Times, 24 Mar 1910) before she was eventually placed at the Kansas State Training School in Winfield, where the 1920 census records her (Ancestry.com, 1920 U.S. Federal Census, Walnut, Cowley, Kansas, Roll T625_528, p. 7B).

After the wedding, Ottomar petitioned the state judicial authority at Königsee to have Clara formally declared legitimate — a standard legal procedure available to couples who married after the birth of a child (Archion: Döschnitz-Meura, Taufen 1868–1889, Bild 7). The rescript was issued on 9 February 1872 and annotated into the parish baptismal register. This administrative remedy conferred full legal legitimacy on Clara before both state and church.³

The household in Döschnitz continued to grow steadily through the 1870s and into the 1880s. Following Clara and Emil in birth order were Lydia (1873), Rudolph (1875), Carl (1877), Augusta (1880) — named for Pauline’s father August, the clearest trace of the Möller line in the Kansas generation’s names — and Gottlob (1883) (Archion: Döschnitz-Meura, Taufen 1868–1889, Bilder 7, 35, 54, 77, 99, 120, 157).

Leaving for America

By the spring of 1885, Pauline’s father and stepmother had been dead six and two years, respectively. Meanwhile, the contracting Döschnitz economy had been placing increased strain on the household for well over a decade. This is seen in Ottomar’s fluctuating professional fortunes during this period, as documented in the church birth records of his children. He appears variously in these pages as an *Oeconom* (independent farm operator), *Fleischer* (butcher), *Landwirt* (farmer), and by December of 1883 a *Handarbeiter* (manual day-laborer). Economic pressures doubtless factored into the family’s decision to migrate across the Atlantic to join Ottomar’s older brother Robert, now a Kansas homesteader, whom they had not seen in nearly 20 years (Archion: Döschnitz-Meura, Taufen 1868–1889, Bilder 77–157; Thüringisches Staatsarchiv Rudolstadt, Auswandererdatenbank, Entry 396; Bock, Ryan E., 2021/2024). It is reasonable to infer that the brothers maintained contact — without such communication, it is difficult to account for how Ottomar would have known to follow Robert there — though no letters between them have survived.

On 6 May 1885, Ottomar and Pauline boarded the *S.S. Frisia* in Hamburg with their seven children. Pauline was 40 years old and pregnant with their eighth child (Staatsarchiv Hamburg, Band 054 C, p. 512; Ancestry.com, M237, List 588). They reached Smith County by 25 May. Lena was born in Lebanon that autumn, the first of the family born on American soil.

The Möller half-siblings — Eline, Luise Agnes, Ida, Hermann, and Anna — remained in and around Döschnitz. The Möllers maintained a presence in the village for many years, alongside Bocks, Biehls, Heisslers, and Rosenbusches (grabsteine.genealogy.net, Friedhof Döschnitz). Whether Pauline maintained correspondence with any of them after 1885 is not known. Emil Bock and his family may have visited some of them during his one and only return trip to Germany in 1912, which included visits throughout the Schwarza valley region (Bock, Emil G., 1912a; 1912b).

³ Following the family’s immigration to Kansas, Pauline and Ottomar quietly pursued rescripts of a different kind, backdating their marriage by several years and post-dating Clara’s birth year to 1869 (as reflected on her gravestone in the North Oak Cemetery in Lebanon, Kansas).

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